

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, April 11, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Absent:

At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Stone to accept the minutes of the March 14, 2018, City Council meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-0 with 1 abstain (Mayor Lovett as she wasn’t at that meeting).

A motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Ms. Lessard to accept the minutes of the March 28, 2018, City Council meeting.

Voice vote: motion carried 7-0 with 1 abstain (Mr. Koloski as he wasn’t at that meeting).

MAYOR'S NOTES

Sara Pope spoke about Donate Life. In 2012 her mother (Tracy Pope) received a kidney donation from her father (Scott Pope). She said almost everyone can donate life. She introduced several people in the audience who had either received a donation or they had a family member who had received a donation.

Mayor Lovett presented a Donate Life proclamation to Sara Pope.

Mayor Lovett's Notes:

- There will be a joint meeting of the Council and School Board April 17, 6:30 p.m., Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center
- A Good Scout Award Luncheon was held to honor former Councilor Carolyn Towle
- April is Child Abuse Prevention Month and
- she asked that when Maggie Monroe-Cassel spoke during Citizens Forum to suspend Council Rules to allow her to speak for more than 5 minutes
- Peer recovery services (funding request) will be on the May 2nd Governor & Council agenda
- Clarified that the amount given to Southwestern Community Services for FY18 for bus transportation was \$25,000

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Mr. McNutt's comments:

- Economic Development – 44 building permits in March with estimated \$3 million cost of construction
- New Farmers Market will start Saturday, May 26th at the Visitors Center Green
 - Eric Zengota, Ward 2, said the Market will run 9 a.m. to 1 p.m.
- Main Street Project will start May 7. Contractor will have an engineer on site working with homeowners and businesses. Work is expected to go into November. They will start at the Leo's Market end of Main Street by Union Street. Rebecca Vinduska is the City's point of contact for the project
- April is Cleanup Month. Tire Takeback will be Saturday, April 21, 8 a.m. to 4 p.m., at the Transfer Station, 875 Washington Street. This event is free to citizens (Transfer Station sticker required). Businesses may not participate
- May 7-May11 will be Spring Cleanup. Public Works will pick up leaves in biodegradable bags. If residents have excess sand from the winter storms, they can put it in biodegradable bags and Public Works will pick it up

Mr. Koloski said on April 16, 8:00 a.m. to 1:30 p.m., he will work with Stevens High School students to clean up the Mulberry Street, Park Avenue, Bluff Avenue area.

Mayor Lovett said there is a pile of tires on Arrowhead to the right of the tree line. She asked if they are no longer needed for Reach the Peak, if they could be disposed of.

Scott Sweet, Public Works Director, said regarding the Main Street Project, they will put a notice in the newspaper and a new webpage will be updated weekly showing where the detours will be. Mobilization will start May 7 and he expects excavation will start May 14.

Mr. Sweet said on Saturday a 10-inch water main broke in front of the dentist's office on Broad Street. There was a longitudinal crack in the top of the pipe. It was fixed by 6 p.m. We lost a few hundred thousand gallons of water. There was no damage to the buildings. Public Works will patch the road when the hotmix plant opens. The pipe is 100 years old. There have not been many pipe breaks on Broad Street.

Mayor Lovett wants the cost of the break in Public Works' monthly report. Mr. Sweet said Public Works keeps track of those expenses to know when to add it to the CIP (Capital Improvements Plan). Mayor Lovett wants the information given to the Council to determine when to expend the funds.

Mr. Damren asked if there is a system in place to send out an email blast to let Councilors or the public know what happened. Mr. McNutt said the City has an "eblast" system, but it is not available on Saturday. Mayor Lovett said if a system is available to let people know right away when things happen, that would be helpful.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Licensing Board

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Mr. Koloski to re-appoint Robert White, Jr. to seat 3 of the Licensing Board.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Maggie Monroe-Cassel, Executive Director of TLC Family Resource Center, said that TLC supports families in Sullivan and lower Grafton Counties. April is Child Abuse Awareness Month. A major part of TLC's work is to prevent child abuse and neglect. Childhood is a time to be carefree and that is why they chose pinwheels as a symbol of child abuse awareness. Our DCYF (Division of Children, Youth and Families) office is one of the top reporters for child abuse and neglect within the state.

OLD BUSINESS

Community Cleanup Update

Mr. Koloski asked about the need to have liability release forms for the Community Cleanup. Mr. McNutt said according to Primex, the Community Cleanup is a City-sponsored activity, but many communities require liability release forms. It is up to the community. He said he heard some people may not show up because of the requirement for the release forms. Ms. Lessard said some people at the Claremont Senior Center have refused to sign such forms.

There was a brief discussion about using the forms and not deterring citizens from wanting to participate. Ms. Russell will make copies of the form for the Councilors to reference and discussion will continue after the break.

Mr. McNutt said the Cleanup is on the City's website, on the News page. Mayor Lovett suggested team leaders email information to the City Manager for posting.

Mr. Sweet talked about "hotspots." Public Works will cleanup Washington Street because of the heavy traffic. He suggested teams could choose Grissom Lane as long as everyone wears reflective vests. Public Works will supply vests, gloves and bags. There is not a lot of trash in neighborhoods; there is more on the back roads.

Mayor Lovett said she and Mr. Pope will cleanup Grissom Lane on April 22nd, Earth Day.

Mr. McNutt asked Mr. Zullo the cost for t-shirts that his employees wear. Mr. Zullo said it is about \$8-\$10 per shirt. Mr. McNutt said perhaps next year the City could get dayglow shirts with Claremont Cleanup Corps. written on them.

Mr. Zullo said on April 22nd he and Mr. Stone will cleanup Paddy Hollow Road, Windy Hill Road and Hewitt Road. He'll collect the bags and take them to the Transfer Station.

Carolyn Towle, Ward 1, said she would be willing to ask people to help clean up the Chestnut Street and Chestnut Street Extension area.

Mayor Lovett said team leaders will coordinate with the City Manager. For information, residents should contact team leaders.

Mr. Sweet said some entrances to the City are on state-maintained roads. He can reach out to the state to cleanup those areas.

Mr. McNutt asked about using County prisoners for the cleanup. Mr. Sweet said he is trying to get some for May 7-11 for bag pickup.

Mayor Lovett brought up the issue of sand left over from the winter snow/ice removal. Mr. Sweet said Public Works would pick up sand May 7-11 if it is put in the paper leaf bags or in 5-gallon buckets (buckets will be emptied and left behind) and leave it beside the road.

Capital Improvements Plan

Mike McCrory, City Planner, said the CIP (Capital Improvements Plan) was prepared by the Claremont Planning Board. He is the staff representative to the Planning Board and he worked through the process with the steering committee. He said the Chair of the Planning Board, Mayor Lovett, Finance Director Mary Walter and Mr. McNutt developed the CIP. The Planning Board approved it March 26. The CIP is a planning document. It is the Master Plan, in practice. It includes infrastructure projects, building projects and renovation projects. This is a guidance document. It helps recognize projects that need to be done. He said Department Heads had input. It is a 6-year timeframe.

Mr. Damren asked about body cams and dashboard cams for the Police Department. Mr. McNutt said Police Chief Chase is getting information on them.

Mr. McNutt said the CIP helps when he is talking with other managers. He's been meeting with neighboring managers and they have been looking at high-dollar items to see if we can share services or regionalize in order to save money.

Mayor Lovett asked for a summary of the projects that have been completed from the last CIP.

Mr. Koloski would like to see what items didn't carry forward from the last CIP.

Mr. McCrory said the committee talked about the vehicle fleet, but they decided to stick with brick and mortar. They still need to figure out vehicles. Mr. Koloski would like to see the plan.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Damren that whereas the Claremont Planning Board, pursuant to RSA 674:7, has prepared and approved a Capital Improvement Program for fiscal years 2019-2024, and now desires to submit its recommendations to the Mayor and City Council for consideration as part of the Council's annual budget review process, the Claremont City Council hereby accepts the fiscal year 2019-2024 Capital Improvement Program as approved on March 26, 2018 by the Claremont Planning Board. The Claremont City Council hereby authorizes the City Manager or his designees to incorporate the recommendations contained in the fiscal year 2019-2024 Capital Improvement Program into the annual budget review process and authorizes the Claremont Planning Board to provide updates to the Capital Improvement Program on an annual basis to maintain and improve the City's credit rating and fiscal health.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Volunteer Service Statement & Release Agreement

Mr. Damren had no issue with the form and think we should use it.

Ms. Lessard was in favor of using it.

Mr. McNutt said the Community Cleanup is a City-Sponsored activity which would allow it to be covered under the City's insurance.

Mr. O'Hearne asked if the inmates sign a waiver.

Mr. Sweet said they are covered under the County, so the City does not have them sign a waiver.

Messrs. O'Hearne and Pope would like to know what legal has to say.

Mr. Koloski has no issue with this form. He asked how to police this going forward.

Mr. Pope would like to use this form for this event. He would like a legal opinion of what needs a waiver.

Mayor Lovett said she heard consensus of the Council to use the waiver for this event.

Councilors asked for a list (and maybe pictures) of items not to pick up (i.e. one-pot meth labs).

NEW BUSINESS

Schedule Budget Hearing Dates

Mr. McNutt said it was the Department Heads' desire to have a budget meeting on one Saturday. The Police Department will deliver the budget books to the Councilors on May 2nd.

Mayor Lovett said the Council has until June 30 to approve the budget.

Mr. Damren suggested having a preliminary budget discussion at the regular Council meeting on May 9th and department presentations on Saturday.

Ms. Walter said if Councilors asked the City Manager questions at the May 9th meeting, it would give Directors a chance to research the answers for the Saturday meeting.

Mayor Lovett said an all-day session could be rough, she suggested remaining flexible for the afternoon.

There was consensus of the Council to hold a budget meeting on Saturday, May 12, 9 a.m. to 5 p.m.

Review of Policies and Assignment to Policy Committee

Mayor Lovett said one of the Council Goals & Objectives for 2018 is to review policies and according to the Charter, Council is to review ordinances every 5 years. She suggested, based on recent work of the Council, to look at the ordinances that pertain to the water and sewer rates, in Chapter 20, Article 4, Division 2 & 3. She said at the March 14 meeting that Mr. Koloski talked about a policy that gives guidance to the Council before accepting donations for such things as the Dog Park and cemetery lighting to ensure projects move forward and money doesn't just sit on the books. She thinks that would be more of a Finance Committee thing. Mr. Damren, Chair of the Finance Committee, said they would consider that after they have gone through a couple of items. She said she thinks the water and sewer rate ordinance should go to the Policy Committee.

Mr. Pope, Chair of the Policy Committee, said they could look at the donation acceptance policy and the water and sewer rates should go to the Finance Committee, but it would be good for the Policy Committee to look at both.

Mr. Pope said the Zoning Board of Adjustment (ZBA) has asked to review the setbacks in the City center. He would like the Chair of the ZBA to speak to the Policy Committee about why the ZBA is bringing this forward.

Mr. Pope said they have worked on the lead policy. He would like Mayor Lovett to speak to the Policy Committee on that.

Mr. Pope said the goal is to restart the Policy Committee meetings on May 17.

Mayor Lovett said last fall when the Goddard Block Project came up, they requested, and received, a parking variance of one parking space per unit instead of 1.5 per unit. She thinks the current ordinance should be amended for that one thing so others don't have to go through the variance process. She thinks it could be handled at the Council level and not have to go to the Policy Committee. She would like that on the May 9 agenda.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Mr. Damren said the Finance Committee is working on reserve funds for the Water and Sewer Enterprise Funds.

Mayor Lovett said the Amtrak Committee is moving forward with the Station Host Program. It will be separate from the ad hoc committee. It is an all-volunteer program. Three people from Washington, DC, will be here April 23, 9 a.m. to 12 noon, CSB Community Center, for host training. The Amtrak Committee is working on initiatives to introduce more people to train travel. A trip has been organized to go to Brattleboro and back. It's a 50-minute trip. People will stay in Brattleboro for a few hours and then return. 44 people have signed up.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Mr. Koloski would like to look into how the Personnel Advisory Board members are appointed and to make sure the language hasn't changed from the Charter.

Mayor Lovett would like Mr. McNutt to look into ways to communicate with the community (i.e. alert system).

Mr. Pope talked about state tax initiatives for improvements in new construction. He would like to revisit it this summer. He has heard from some business people that would like to see what they can do for expansions.

Mayor Lovett would like an update on 79E (Community Revitalization Tax Relief Incentive (RSA 79E)). Mr. McNutt said he is looking at the possibility of having a 79E enabling legislation for residential home improvements.

Mayor Lovett said Council needs to invite State Representatives to a Council meeting in the summer to discuss what the Council wants them to address legislatively. We have to have it ready by fall. Mr. McNutt said there needs to be time to write it and then have it looked at by their legal counsel.

Mayor Lovett said there is nothing urgent for the second Council meeting of April. She suggested there be no Council meeting on April 25. Mr. McNutt said there is nothing from City Staff for the April 25 meeting. It was the consensus of the Council to not have a meeting on April 25.

Mayor Lovett said there will be a joint Council/School Board meeting on April 17.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

NON-PUBLIC SESSION PURSUANT TO RSA 91-A:3,II(a) – PERSONNEL

A motion was made by Mr. Zullo and seconded by Mr. O'Hearne to go into the Non-Public Session pursuant to RSA 91-A:3,II(a) – Personnel and to invite Mr. McNutt into the session.

Roll call vote:

Lessard - yes

O'Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Damren - yes

Zullo - yes

Koloski - yes

Pope - yes
Lovett – yes
Motion carried 8-0.

Non-Public minutes were taken by Mr. Pope.

Description of matters discussed: Quarterly evaluation of the City Manager.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to exit the Non-Public Session.

Roll call vote:
Lessard - yes
O’Hearne - yes
Stone - yes
Damren - yes
Zullo - yes
Koloski - yes
Pope - yes
Lovett – yes
Motion carried 8-0.

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:29 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council